

A Guide to Noun Clauses

A noun clause is a type of subordinate clause (dependent clause) that acts as a noun in a sentence. Most of the time, noun clauses begin with a relative pronoun like *what* or *whatever*. In this noun clause example, “I like who you are,” the noun clause “who you are” acts as a single noun, specifically the direct object of the verb *like*.

What is a noun clause?

A noun clause gets its name because it is simply a clause that acts like a noun. A clause is any group of words that contains both a subject and a verb, but noun clauses are a specific type of clause called a subordinate clause.

Also known as dependent clauses, subordinate clauses cannot stand alone and must join an independent clause. That means sentences with noun clauses will always have at least two verbs (because they will always have two clauses). Let’s look at a noun clause example:

Whoever wrote the graffiti needs grammar lessons.

This sentence has two clauses: an independent clause and a noun clause. The noun clause is the phrase “whoever wrote the graffiti”; this group of words work together as a single noun and include both a subject (*whoever*) and a verb (*wrote*).

Here’s where it gets a little tricky. The noun clause “whoever wrote the graffiti” is also the subject of the independent clause. The verb of the independent clause is *needs*, and its direct object is *grammar lessons*.

Let’s say the noun clause represents someone named Cody. In other words, Cody wrote the graffiti. We could rewrite the first sentence as:

Cody needs grammar lessons.

Essentially, the noun clause “whoever wrote the graffiti” replaces the individual noun “Cody.” The noun clause acts just like the individual noun it represents, but gives a little more detail by introducing a new verb into the sentence.

How to use noun clauses

Noun clauses can do anything a regular noun can do. This means they can act as a:

- subject
- direct object
- indirect object
- prepositional object
- predicate nominative

Noun clauses completely replace individual nouns in a sentence, no matter how long the noun clauses are or how many words they contain. For example, let’s look at a sentence without a noun clause.

*My dog eats **things**.*

The individual noun *things* is the direct object of *eats*. If we want to give more detail, we can replace the noun *things* with a more descriptive noun clause. Not only do noun clauses contain an extra verb for more details, they can also include other words like adverbs and prepositional phrases.

*My dog eats **whatever falls on the floor**.*

Notice how our new noun clause has its own subject (*whatever*) and verb (*falls*). These are different from the independent clause’s subject (*my dog*) and verb (*eats*). The noun clause also contains the additional prepositional phrase “on the floor,” which offers even more information. No matter how many words or phrases it contains, the noun clause still acts as only a single noun, replacing *things*.

What do noun clauses start with?

Noun clauses are fairly easy to recognise if you know what they start with. Noun clauses can begin with relative pronouns and certain subordinating conjunctions. Here's a list of common words that start noun clauses to help you identify them when reading or use them when writing.

Relative pronouns

- who
- what
- where
- when
- why
- how
- that
- which

Indefinite relative pronouns

- whoever
- whomever
- whatever
- wherever
- whenever
- whichever

Subordinating conjunctions

- if
- whether

Noun clause examples

1 Noun clause examples: Subject

The subject is the person or thing that does the main action in a sentence. The subject usually comes at the beginning of a sentence.

Whoever wins the race gets the trophy.

Whichever you pick is fine with me.

2 Noun clause examples: Direct object

The direct object is the noun that receives the action of transitive verbs.

I couldn't see ***whether it was day or night***.

The chess player didn't know ***if they could win***.

3 Noun clause examples: Indirect object

In sentences with transitive verbs, indirect objects receive the direct object. They typically come between the verb and the direct object.

She told ***whoever would listen*** her sad story.

4 Noun clause examples: Prepositional object

Nouns act as objects to prepositions like *on*, *about*, or *for*. Together, the preposition and its object form a prepositional phrase.

*Our suspect depends on **who owns the murder weapon**.*

*The people want to hear about **why you're running for Congress**.*

5 Noun clause examples: Predicate nominative

Predicate nominatives are nouns that follow linking verbs like *be* or *seem*. Instead of describing an action like other verbs, linking verbs describe the subject—the action is simply existing.

*Is this **what you wanted**?*

*His reason for being late was **that his cat got sick**.*

Keep in mind the relative pronoun *that* is often optional and can be removed from a sentence. In the next example, it is still assumed but not stated.

*His reason for being late was **his cat got sick**.*

Noun clauses vs. relative clauses

Although both noun clauses and relative clauses can begin with relative pronouns, noun clauses function differently from relative clauses. A noun clause completely replaces an individual noun in a sentence. However, relative clauses don't replace anything; they simply add new information. They modify nouns instead of taking their place.

[NOUN CLAUSE] *Karen needs to speak with **whoever runs the store**.*

[RELATIVE CLAUSE] *Karen needs to speak with the person **who runs the store**.*

In the first example above, the noun clause “whoever runs the store” acts as the object of the preposition *with*. But in the second example, “the person” is the object of the preposition *with*. The relative clause “who runs the store” is an adjective phrase that describes and modifies “the person”, but does not replace it like a noun clause does.

Noun clause vs. noun phrase

Just like a noun clause, a noun phrase is also a group of words that work together as a single noun. The main difference between a noun clause and a noun phrase is that **noun clauses have verbs, but noun phrases do not**. Noun clauses also usually start with relative pronouns, unlike noun phrases.

[NOUN CLAUSE] *The gas station clerk told us **how we can go from Main Street to the highway**.*

[NOUN PHRASE] *The gas station clerk told us **directions from Main Street to the highway**.*

In the noun clause example, “how we can go from Main Street to the highway” has a subject (*we*) and a verb (*go*), the necessary parts of a clause. The prepositional phrases “from Main Street” and “to the highway” act as adverbs that describe the verb *go*.

The noun phrase “directions from Main Street to the highway” does not have a verb. The prepositional phrases “from Main Street” and “to the highway” act as adjectives to describe the noun *directions*.

In both of these examples, the group of words work together as a single noun that is the direct object of *told* and explains what the gas station clerk said.

Noun clause FAQs

What is a noun clause?

A noun clause is a type of subordinate clause (dependent clause) that acts as a noun in a sentence. In the noun clause example, "I like who you are," the noun clause "who you are" acts as a single noun, specifically the direct object of the verb *like*.

How do noun clauses work?

In noun clauses, the words all work together to replace a single noun. You can use noun clauses in all the same places you can use a normal noun: as the subject, direct object, indirect object, prepositional object, or predicate nominative.

What's the difference between a noun clause and a noun phrase?

Both noun clauses and noun phrases are groups of words that work together as a single noun. The difference is that noun clauses contain a verb, but noun phrases do not. Noun clauses also usually start with a relative pronoun, whereas noun phrases do not.

NOUN CLAUSES PRACTICE EXERCISE

Step 1. In the passage below, select each clause by identifying the Main Verb Phrase.

Step 2. From the highlighted Main Verb Phrase, determine if the clause is a nominal clause or not.

nominal clause
What was left of Margot's mind reeled. She could hear the listless, scraping sounds of fingertips against the door. It haunted her to consider nominal clause that a sea of faces lurked outside. They were faces nominal clause she once knew in a different light, but now they were putrid reflections of squalor and decay. There was only nominal clause what she could glean from their lifeless eyes: the grim reminder nominal clause that she was alone. She tried to ignore nominal clause what appeared before her, but she truly believed nominal clause she was the last bastion of humanity. Death awaited her outside.